



Vietcong

Tour of duty

Vietcong is the story of a platoon stationed right near enemy lines while the war between North and South Vietnam was in full swing. If you're a fan of classic rock, buy this game just for the sound track—the game kicks off with you in a chopper and *Hey Joe* by Jimi Hendrix in the background. The game has good graphics, excellent sound and very partial AI. The enemy AI will outsmart you at every turn, while your team can't seem to find its way around a rock.

Weapons are beautifully and faithfully rendered. A nice touch is the wound placement—if you shoot someone in the arm, his arm, and not his chest, gets bloodied. Voice acting is impeccable and weapons are full sounding—not tinny and off like in some games. Ambient sounds, as you



wander through the jungle, are really fantastic. Birds flapping, monkeys screeching, numerous frogs in a swamp; they're all there. Another neat aspect of

the game is that natives speak to you in authentic Vietnamese. There are no English subtitles. Your only hope is to find someone who speaks both languages.

Vietcong is one of the most carefully crafted and intricate games on any platform. The amount of history incorporated into this game, and the amount of minute details draw you into believing that you're actually a soldier in Vietnam. There's even a Quick Fight mode, which you can play through various multi-player style levels against some good

AI. In the end there is a real sense of accomplishment in beating *Vietcong*; even on the easiest settings, this game will still test your skills.

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Pterodon ■ **Publisher:** Gathering ■ **System requirements:** 700 MHz CPU, 256 MB RAM, 1.8 GB hard disk space, 32 MB video card, DirectX 8.1 ■ **Price:** US\$ 29.99 ■ **Web site:** www.vietcong-game.com
Rating: ★★★★★



Tony Hawk's Pro Skater 4

Break all barriers

The major change in *Tony Hawk's Pro Skater 4*, as compared to earlier versions, is the time constraint to the missions. In earlier versions, missions were available at the onset of a level, and had to be completed in a given time. This time around, you can freely skate the environs and have fun; until you trigger a mission, and a timer starts ticking. Missions are handed out by skaters or bystanders. These can range from rescues and challenges, to races. Irrespective of whether you succeed or fail a mission, the game continues and you're free to retry, hunt for other challenges or just skate around without a care in the world.

You can complete these missions, which get difficult incrementally, to earn



cash and pro points. Cash can be used to unlock several features in the game, and pro points are used to unlock professional challenges. Vehicles can now be used to Grind,

Wallride and perform the familiar Car Plant. What makes them really useful is the ability to hitch a ride by holding onto the rear bumper—seen in several skateboarding movies, and is called 'Skitchin' in skater lingo.

The game has certain enhancements in the sound department too. It includes a couple of great tracks—Iron Maiden's *Number of the Beast* and AC/DC's *TNT*. The soundtrack now comes with a playlist, which can be used to switch on or off certain tracks and also set the sequence in which they'll play. Iron Maiden's famous band mascot Eddie (Metal

Head) is featured as one of the secret skaters! Those who're going try this series for the first time, be prepared to be hooked!

Genre: Simulation ■ **Developer:** Neversoft Entertainment ■ **Publisher:** Activision ■ **System requirements:** 800 MHz CPU, 256 MB RAM, DirectX 8.1, 32 MB GeForce2 or Radeon graphics card, 700 MB hard disk space ■ **Price:** NA ■ **Web site:** <http://www.aspyr.com/games.php/pc/thps4>
Rating: ★★★★★